

Role Reversal

Kanjar men are appointed to protect the villages that have considered them criminals for centuries



THE NIGHT PATROL

By Rohit Parihar

It's a community that finds it difficult to shed the label stuck on it by kings, the British and common people since historic times. The Scheduled Caste Kanjar community of Rajasthan was said to earn its bread through theft, prostitution and manufacture of illicit liquor. In 1871, the British notified them as a criminal tribe. That may not have been true, but with successive governments doing little for them and with almost no land holdings, the tribe did take to criminal activities.

Today, as the Kanjars live in colonies across the state, villages in their vicinity have devised a unique way to deal with them: they pay the Kanjars to guard their villages. The irony of the situation is that the Kanjars have to compensate the loss in case of a theft.

In Aunwa village of Tonk district, the Kanjars have 40 houses, some of which look like bunkers with stones piled up to three ft around them. The men guard Aunwa and adjacent villages for which they get either five kg grain every six months or Rs 100 a year. They also provide blanket protection to pilgrims; the organisers of

pilgrimages take a deposit which is returned along with their wages on the successful completion of the tours. When Kanjar men are away, their women do duty.

"We act as insurance against theft," Gujjar Mal Kanjar, 50, a village guard, says with pride. Now, the Kanjars have risen—they boast of a teacher and a driver. The system helped Gujjar Mal's son Vinod become the first school teacher in the community's history. Baniani Kanjar, 60, who has a family of 12 children and owns less than a hectare, guards the adjacent village of Kanwara. Baniani, whose neighbours say was a master thief, is consulted by the police to identify robbers. Once he even had to pay for a theft but then got the thief arrested.

The community now stares at another trend—their demand as guards is on the decline as thieves have started targeting cities. Aunwa ex-sarpanch and former chief minister Vasundhara Raje's media adviser Mahendra Bhardwaj says: "Giving responsibility can help uplift such communities." In times of runaway change, attitudes towards the Kanjars still have to shift. ■